The scientist C.V. Raman liked to say that his greatest discovery was the weather in Bangalore. Fortunately, the day of our Premier party was in keeping with this—a cloudless sky, a gentle breeze blowing, and the Green Barbet calling in the middle distance. After the *bisi bélé* had been consumed, it was time for the speeches.

The first tribute was offered by Chiranjeev Singh, a Kannada scholar of Sikh extraction, and one of the state's outstanding civil servants. Chiranjeev recalled how he and his senior in the service, Christopher Lynn, built the secretariat library more or less from the selection at Premier's. Then he added: 'There is one thing that I want to tell you about Mr Shanbhag, which speaks to the kind of man, or businessman, that he is. He has never entered a government office.'

Following Chiranjeev was Tara Chandavarkar, for long one half of the city's most reputed architectural firm, for long also a great patron of music, and servant of the suffering and the elderly. 'Those of you present here,' began Mrs Chandavarkar, 'know of Premier's as a bookshop. But I have also known it as a crèche run for charity.' Apparently, she would leave her grandchildren in Shanbhag's shop while she herself went off for a meeting with a client.

Other speakers that day included Narendra Pani and Janaki Nair, who remembered how, when they were impecunious students, Mr Shanbhag would allow them to take away books and pay when they could. (Years later, they became established authors, and Premier's proudly displayed, and sold, their books.)

In the end, though, it was the sly old man who had the last word. As the party dispersed he commanded us to wait, disappeared into his car, and returned with a gift for each of us, this, of course, a book.

At the risk of sounding snobbish, I should say that Premier's had the most cultivated tastes of all the bookshops in India. It is only here that works of literature and history outnumbered (and outsold) books designed to augment your bank balance or cure your soul. When it came to fiction,